and I would not have approved it if anyone had suggested it to me.

Yes, I believed in helping the Contras; but no one, including presidents, is above the law. The Iranian initiative was secret, but I was assured that everything about it was legal. And one thing about the Iranian initiative will never change: we did bring home three hostages.

But looking back now, with the benefit of hindsight and the Tower Board's report, it appears that, despite Israel's repeated assurances that we were dealing with responsible moderates in Iran, some of those "moderates" may have had links to the Ayatollah Khomeini's government and were trying to obtain weapons under false pretenses. And despite Israel's endorsement of them, we now know that some of the middlemen we were dealing with during the Iran initiative (and who helped us win the freedom of three hostages) behaved at times like bait-and-switch con men: They would make promises, then renege on them, lying to McFarlane, North, Poindexter, and others with the sole intention of profiteering. During this process, apparently, Oliver North and others at the NSC agreed to certain things —such as promising secret U.S. intelligence data to the Iranians for use in their war with Iraq—that I was never told about.

Because of his illness and subsequent death, I never had a chance to learn from Bill Casey what he knew about Iran-Contra. Probably only John Poindexter and Oliver North know all the answers. In this regard, I've often wondered if we didn't move too fast after Ed Meese uncovered the memorandum that disclosed the diversion of funds to the Contras. Ed said that Poindexter and North shouldn't remain in their jobs another day, and Don Regan agreed; he said it would be important to show that we took decisive action as soon as the diversion of funds was discovered.